



LOOKING FOR A SILVER LINING

Tough times: Currently languishing at 11th in the points table, CFC is heading towards another underwhelming season. M. VEDHAN

Chennaiyin FC's loss to Hyderabad FC did not deter the **spirit of its fans**, as the team struggles for consistency in its performances.

It's not very common to see the home fans of a losing team give a Viking clap to the opposition victors. However, that is exactly what the Chennaiyin FC fans did after their side went down to Hyderabad FC.

Thangboi Singto's team, with an all-Indian contingent, overcame the odds to beat a fancied CFC and brought up its first win of the season. And the Supermachans, although modest in numbers, did not shy away from expressing their appreciation.

"A big salute to the Chennaiyin fans because they understood the situation despite supporting their home team. We had all the Indian boys tonight, and we were like underdogs. So, underdogs are always cheered upon, and today they did that," Singto said after the match.

The HFC coach was also vocal about what this victory means to the young squad.

"What CFC fans did was something commendable for Indian football. Of course, the foreigners are there always to help us, but when the Indian boys do well, I think they need a little bit of pat on the back, and those types of shouts really propel their confidence to a higher stage," he added.

Sankar Narayanan EH

A call to the fans

It has been four years since Chennaiyin FC last made the ISL playoffs, which included a memorable night at the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium. Close to 18,000 people turned up to watch their home side whallop FC Goa 4-1 in the first leg of the semifinal.

In the times since then, nights like

those have been few and far between. Currently languishing at 11th in the points table, CFC is heading towards another underwhelming season. The club's showing on the pitch was reflective of the poor attendance at the Nehru Stadium when Chennaiyin took on the then-league topper Odisha FC in a late evening clash. Despite just close to 1000 people turning up for the clash, in a nearly 36,000 seater stadium, the team provided a grandstand finish, with a stoppage-time winner.

Head coach Owen Coyle, who led the club back in 2019-20 in his first stint, feels the onus is on the team to bring the fans back into the stadium.

"It's all connected. When I came in (2019), there weren't big crowds initially. We have a loyal fanbase. When we are winning, the city feels good and people want to come out